Digital Literacy Project Report

Course Code: CSE0001

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Introduction

This project was completed as part of the CSE0001 Digital Literacy course at VIT Bhopal University. The scenario for this project was to act as a Student Digital Ambassador — someone responsible for helping fellow students navigate the digital world responsibly and effectively. Across five tasks, I explored practical aspects of digital literacy including visual communication, building a professional online presence, using coding and collaboration platforms, professional email etiquette, and cybercrime awareness. Each task helped me understand not just how to use digital tools, but why using them responsibly and thoughtfully matters in an academic and professional context. This report documents my work, observations, and personal reflections for each task.

Task 1 – Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

For this task, I created a one-page digital literacy awareness infographic using Canva. I chose Canva because it is free, browser-based, and has a wide range of templates that made it easy to organise information visually without needing advanced design skills. My infographic covers three main topics: what digital literacy means, safe internet practices for students, and tips for maintaining a professional online presence. I used a clean layout with icons, short text blocks, and colour coding to make each section easy to read at a glance. The goal was to create something that a first year student could look at quickly and immediately understand the key points.

One thing I found interesting while making the infographic was how much the layout and colour choices affect how information is received. I initially tried a very text-heavy design but it looked cluttered and hard to follow. Switching to shorter bullet points with icons made it much cleaner and more engaging. This experience made me realise that visual communication is its own skill — it is not just about having the right information, but presenting it in a way that the audience can actually absorb. The exported infographic is saved in the task-1-presentation/ folder of the repository.

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

For this task, I set up and updated my profiles on three platforms: GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. GitHub is a platform for hosting and sharing code projects. It acts as a live portfolio for developers and is widely checked by recruiters and internship coordinators. I created a profile README on my GitHub that includes my name, branch, year, and a brief note about what I hope to learn during my engineering degree. LinkedIn is a professional networking platform used for connecting with industry professionals, finding internships, and showcasing academic and professional achievements. I updated my Education section with my current degree details at VIT Bhopal University. Kaggle is a data science and machine learning community platform where students can practice with real datasets and participate in competitions.

Over the next four years, I plan to use GitHub to document all my projects so that my progress is visible and trackable. I will use LinkedIn to build connections with seniors, alumni, and professionals in the field of AI and computer science. Kaggle will help me practice data-related skills outside the classroom. Setting up these profiles early felt important because it gives me time to build them authentically rather than rushing to fill them in during final year when placements begin. Screenshots of all three profiles are saved in the task-2-portfolio/ folder.

Task 3 – Coding and Collaboration Platforms

For Part A of this task, I created an account on HackerRank and completed the Solve Me First challenge, which is an introductory problem designed to familiarise new users with how the platform works. The challenge involved reading two integers and printing their sum — simple in terms of logic, but useful for understanding how HackerRank's code editor and submission system functions. I also attempted the Python Introduction challenge to practice basic syntax. A screenshot of the completed challenge is saved in the task-3-platforms/ folder.

For Part B, I created a Google Form titled 'Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz' with five questions covering topics from this course. The questions test basic knowledge of digital literacy concepts, safe internet practices, and professional communication. The form includes multiple choice questions and one short answer question. The form link is included in the repository README and a screenshot of both the form and the linked Google Sheet response view is saved in task-3-platforms/. These tools are directly useful academically — HackerRank keeps coding skills sharp between assignments, and Google Forms is something I will likely use for surveys, quizzes, and data collection in future projects.

Task 4 – Professional Email and Etiquette Guide

A common situation where poor digital communication causes real problems is when students send casual, unstructured messages to faculty. For example, a student messaging a professor: *"Sir need marks urgently, send asap"* — this comes across as disrespectful and unprofessional. The professor may not respond helpfully, not out of unwillingness, but because the message signals a lack of effort and regard for their time.

What the student should have done instead is write a properly structured email — with a clear subject line, a polite greeting such as "Dear Professor [Name]," a brief explanation of context, and a respectful sign-off. Professional communication is not about being overly formal; it is about showing consideration for the reader. In academic and workplace settings, how you say something often matters just as much as what you are saying.

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness Case Study

Case Study: Phishing Attack Targeting a Student

Phishing is one of the most common forms of cybercrime. It involves an attacker sending a fake message that appears to come from a trusted source, with the goal of tricking the recipient into sharing sensitive information such as login credentials, banking details, or personal data.
A typical scenario involves a college student receiving an email that appears to be from a well-known company offering a paid internship. The email includes a professional logo, a convincing subject line such as 'Urgent: Internship Selection – Immediate Action Required', and a link to a form asking for academic details and email login credentials for 'verification'. The message creates urgency by stating that failure to respond within 12 hours will result in cancellation of the opportunity.

The student, excited and under pressure, fills in the form without verifying the sender's email address or checking whether the company's official website mentions such a program. Within hours, the student begins receiving alerts about suspicious login attempts and unauthorised access to their account.

This type of attack typically targets students and young professionals who are actively looking for opportunities and are therefore more likely to respond quickly without verifying. The consequences include unauthorised account access, potential identity theft, loss of personal data, and significant anxiety and loss of trust in online platforms.

Reflection

What surprised me most while researching this topic was that phishing attacks do not succeed because people are uninformed — they succeed because they are designed to exploit human emotions like excitement and urgency. Even people who know what phishing is can fall for it in the right moment. My own father once fell for a similar scam despite being careful in general. The one habit I will personally change as a result of this task is to always take 30 seconds to verify the sender's email address and check the official website before clicking any link that involves submitting personal information.

Conclusion

This project changed how I think about digital literacy. Before starting, I thought being digitally literate simply meant knowing how to use tools and navigate the internet. After completing all five tasks, I understand it is much more than that. It is about using tools responsibly, communicating professionally, presenting yourself honestly online, and staying alert to risks. Each task taught me something practical that I will carry forward — from designing clear visuals to writing proper emails to verifying online opportunities before acting on them. The GitHub repository built through this project is also something I intend to continue developing throughout my degree as a genuine record of my growth.

References

• Canva – canva.com (used for Task 1 infographic)

• GitHub – github.com (used for Task 2 portfolio and repository)

• LinkedIn – linkedin.com (used for Task 2 portfolio)

• Kaggle – kaggle.com (used for Task 2 portfolio)

• HackerRank – hackerrank.com (used for Task 3 coding practice)

• Google Forms – forms.google.com (used for Task 3 quiz)

• National Cyber Crime Portal – cybercrime.gov.in (referenced in Task 5)

• CERT-In Cyber Safety Guidelines – cert-in.org.in